

Middle East War Updates: 28 February 2026 - 12 July 2026

Educational laboratory corpus for a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) demo.

This document summarizes publicly reported war, diplomacy, and maritime developments across the Middle East from 28 February 2026 through 12 July 2026.

Primary theaters covered: Iran-United States-Israel conflict; Lebanon-Hezbollah front; Strait of Hormuz shipping disruption; and related Gulf-state impacts.

Disclaimer: Compiled for software demonstration and interview-prep purposes. It is not an official government briefing. Dates and events are drawn from open-source reporting (including AP timeline summaries and contemporaneous coverage). Where reporting conflicts, both claims are noted.

How to use this corpus: Ask the RAG chat about specific dates, ceasefire deals, Hormuz status, Lebanon framework talks, or nuclear/sanctions terms.

1. Overview of the Conflict Arc

On 28 February 2026, joint United States and Israeli strikes on Iran killed Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and other senior officials, precipitating a multi-front war. Iran retaliated against Israel and Gulf targets and asserted control over the Strait of Hormuz, a chokepoint that previously carried roughly one-fifth of globally traded oil and natural gas.

Within days, Hezbollah in Lebanon entered the war with rocket fire into northern Israel. Israel responded with air and ground operations that evolved into a sustained occupation of large areas of southern Lebanon.

From early April through mid-June, diplomacy produced fragile ceasefires, failed or partial Hormuz reopenings, a U.S. naval blockade of Iranian ports, and intermittent Israel-Lebanon talks in Washington.

On 17 June 2026, the U.S. and Iran signed an interim memorandum of understanding (MoU) establishing a roughly 60-day negotiation window covering uranium stockpile dilution, sanctions relief, and shipping. Parallel Israel-Lebanon framework talks advanced later in June. Renewed Hormuz incidents and U.S.-Iran strikes in early July threatened to unravel the interim deal as of 12 July 2026.

2. February-March 2026: Opening Strikes and Regional Expansion

28 February 2026 - Opening day. CENTCOM and partner forces began airstrikes against Iran. U.S. warships launched Tomahawk missiles; B-2, B-1, and B-52 aircraft struck fortified ballistic-missile facilities. Israeli and U.S. attacks killed Khamenei and other top officials. Iran launched ballistic missiles toward Israel and several Gulf states; a missile strike was reported against the U.S. Navy Fifth Fleet headquarters area in Bahrain. Iranian forces asserted control over the Strait of Hormuz.

2 March 2026 - Hezbollah front opens. Projectiles launched from Lebanon toward Israel triggered sirens in Haifa and the Upper Galilee. Hezbollah claimed responsibility for attacking an IDF base in Haifa in response to Khamenei's killing. Israel vowed to neutralize the threat and began retaliatory air operations across Lebanon, including Beirut's southern suburbs (Dahieh) and the Beqaa Valley.

Early-mid March 2026 - Israeli ground operations in southern Lebanon expanded. The IDF reported strikes on dozens of targets and operations around towns including Haris, Nabatieh al-Fawqa, and Mayfadoun, with displacement of large civilian populations. Reports cited killings of Hezbollah intelligence and Palestinian Islamic Jihad figures in Lebanon.

8 March 2026 - Iran names Mojtaba Khamenei, a son of the late supreme leader, as the new supreme leader. He had not been seen publicly and was believed to be in hiding after reportedly being injured in the opening strikes.

Late March 2026 - Fighting continued on Iranian, Israeli, Lebanese, and maritime fronts. Oil markets remained volatile as Hormuz transit stayed tightly controlled or blocked for many commercial tankers. Gulf states hosting U.S. forces faced intermittent missile and drone alerts.

3. April 2026: First Ceasefire Window and Hormuz Diplomacy

7 April 2026 - A tenuous two-week ceasefire deal was reached between the United States and Iran. Israel was not included in those discussions, and Israeli operations related to Lebanon continued to be a political flashpoint.

12 April 2026 - U.S. and Iranian negotiators held historic face-to-face talks in Islamabad, Pakistan, for several hours without reaching a final agreement. Pakistan played an early mediation role alongside later Qatari facilitation.

13 April 2026 - U.S. President Donald Trump announced a blockade of Iranian ports intended to pressure Tehran to relinquish its grip on the Strait of Hormuz.

14 April 2026 - Lebanon and Israel held their first direct diplomatic talks in decades in Washington, D.C., under U.S. auspices, focused on de-escalation and security arrangements in southern Lebanon.

17 April 2026 - Iran stated that it had reopened the Strait of Hormuz to shipping. The reopening did not hold; subsequent days saw renewed restrictions and security incidents that again constrained commercial traffic.

21 April 2026 - Trump said the United States was indefinitely extending the ceasefire with Iran, even as local violations and proxy-front fighting continued to be reported.

Late April 2026 - Diplomatic tracks remained open but fragile. Energy markets tracked daily Hormuz transit counts; shipping insurers and operators demanded war-risk premiums and approved routing.

4. May 2026: Escort Attempts and Deepening Lebanon War

3 May 2026 - Trump announced a U.S. effort to guide commercial ships through the Strait of Hormuz. Like the mid-April reopening claim, the escort initiative did not produce a durable free-navigation regime.

Throughout May 2026 - Cross-border fire between Hezbollah and Israel continued. Israeli ground forces pushed deeper into southern Lebanon while airstrikes hit suspected Hezbollah infrastructure. Humanitarian reporting described large-scale displacement from southern Lebanon and severe disruption of civilian services.

31 May 2026 - Israel's ground invasion of Lebanon reached its deepest incursion in more than a quarter-century, according to contemporaneous reporting, as Hezbollah continued rocket and missile fire into northern Israel.

Late May context - Parallel U.S.-Iran talks remained intermittent. Issues on the table included Hormuz freedom of navigation, Iran's highly enriched uranium stockpile, sanctions relief, and the status of fighting involving Hezbollah in Lebanon.

5. June 2026: Interim MoU, Lebanon Framework, and Renewed Strikes

3 June 2026 - Israel and Lebanon said they agreed to renew a fragile ceasefire and create security zones intended to exclude Hezbollah. Fighting resumed quickly after the announcement, underscoring the gap between political frameworks and battlefield realities.

Around 3 June 2026 - Reporting also described intense U.S.-Iran exchanges; one account cited Iranian missiles and drones striking Kuwait International Airport, killing at least one person and wounding more than sixty others during a major escalation wave.

7 June 2026 - Iran fired at Israel in the first such bombardment since the early-April ceasefire took effect. Israel returned fire. The episode marked a clear breakdown of the April pause on the Iran-Israel kinetic channel.

14 June 2026 - Trump said an interim deal with Iran had been reached and would be signed within days. Iranian officials insisted any durable settlement must also end fighting in Lebanon. Pakistani mediation language referenced termination of military operations across fronts, including Lebanon-language Israel disputed in practice by maintaining southern Lebanon deployments.

17 June 2026 - Trump signed an agreement / MoU with Iran. Publicly described elements included: Tehran diluting its stockpile of highly enriched uranium; waiver of certain U.S.-backed sanctions allowing freer Iranian oil sales; reopening pathways for Strait of Hormuz shipping; and a roughly 60-day negotiation window toward a final settlement on nuclear limits, sanctions, and frozen assets.

22 June 2026 - U.S. Vice President JD Vance said new talks with senior Iranian officials in Switzerland created a "good foundation for a successful final deal."

26 June 2026 - Israel and Lebanon announced a U.S.-backed framework agreement described as a first step toward peace, following intensive Washington talks. The framework did not immediately end all Israeli operations or Hezbollah fire; implementation and verification remained contested.

Late June 2026 - Technical talks were expected to address Hormuz governance, sanctions relief sequencing, and Iran's nuclear program. Delays were attributed in part to continued fighting and occupation dynamics in southern Lebanon.

6. July 2026 (1-12 July): MoU Stress Test and Renewed Escalation

1 July 2026 - Host Qatar said U.S. and Iranian negotiators met separately with Qatari and Pakistani mediators and that "positive progress" had been made toward a final deal.

2 July 2026 - Iran's joint military command warned that all oil tankers moving through the Strait of Hormuz must use Iranian-approved routes or face a "forceful response," signaling continued Iranian assertion of maritime control despite interim diplomacy.

4 July 2026 - Iran began a days-long state funeral for the late supreme leader, Khamenei. Talks with the United States on a final war/nuclear settlement were expected to resume after funeral ceremonies concluded (around 11 July in some schedules).

7 July 2026 - Iran was accused of striking three ships in the Strait of Hormuz after traffic had slowly increased-reportedly the most ships in a single day since late April. The United States responded by striking dozens of targets in Iran and reinstating sanctions on Iranian oil sales. Tehran's lead negotiator declared that "the era of bullying and extortion is over."

8 July 2026 - Trump declared the ceasefire "over" but said negotiations could continue, raising market and diplomatic fears of a full return to multi-front war.

9-10 July 2026 - The United States launched further airstrikes against Iran. Iran responded by targeting U.S.-allied Middle East countries; sirens sounded repeatedly in Bahrain (Fifth Fleet headquarters) and missiles were reported toward Kuwait and Qatar. U.S. officials said strikes aimed to degrade Iran's ability to threaten freedom of navigation in Hormuz. Some U.S. strikes reportedly hit bridges in Iran, including routes connected to Mashhad funeral processions.

10 July 2026 - Despite kinetic exchanges, a U.S. official told Al Jazeera that Washington remained committed to negotiations and that technical talks for a lasting peace deal would continue. Core agenda items remained: Strait of Hormuz future rules, Iran's frozen assets, long-term sanctions relief, and Tehran's nuclear program.

Lebanon status as of early-mid July 2026 - Israel occupied roughly one-fifth of Lebanon according to multiple reports, with near-daily attacks since early March. Casualty and displacement figures cited in open reporting included thousands killed and more than one million displaced. Hezbollah rejected some proposed pilot withdrawal zones in U.S.-brokered frameworks.

12 July 2026 - End of this corpus window. The interim June MoU remained under severe stress after early-July Hormuz incidents and mutual U.S.-Iran strikes. Final-deal talks were uncertain in timing; funeral-related delays and ceasefire-violation accusations (especially regarding Lebanon and Hormuz) dominated diplomatic messaging. Global oil prices and shipping insurance rates remained highly sensitive to each day's Hormuz transit and strike reports.

7. Cross-Cutting Themes for RAG Retrieval

Strait of Hormuz: Closed/controlled from 28 February; brief reopenings claimed mid-April and escort attempts in May; MoU sought freer navigation from mid-June; July ship strikes and Iranian route mandates reasserted coercive control.

Ceasefires and MoUs: April 7 two-week U.S.-Iran pause (Israel excluded); April 21 indefinite extension claim; June 17 interim MoU with ~60-day talks; July 8 Trump "ceasefire over" statement amid continued negotiation rhetoric.

Lebanon track: Hezbollah entry 2 March; deep Israeli ground war by 31 May; June 3 and June 26 ceasefire/framework announcements; occupation and verification disputes persisting into July.

Nuclear and sanctions: June 17 terms referenced uranium dilution and sanctions waivers; July 7 U.S. reinstatement of oil-sale sanctions after Hormuz ship attacks; final nuclear limits and frozen-asset release remained negotiation agenda items.

Actors: United States, Israel, Iran (new supreme leader Mojtaba Khamenei), Hezbollah, Lebanon government negotiators, Qatar and Pakistan as mediators, Gulf host states (Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, UAE) affected by missile/drone spillover.

8. Suggested Question Types for the Demo Chat

What happened on 28 February 2026 that started the war?

When did Hezbollah enter the conflict, and how did Israel respond?

Summarize the April 2026 ceasefire and Hormuz developments.

What did the 17 June 2026 U.S.-Iran MoU include?

Describe Israel-Lebanon diplomatic frameworks in June 2026.

Why did the ceasefire come under stress in early July 2026?

What is the status of the Strait of Hormuz across February-July 2026?

Who mediated U.S.-Iran talks in July 2026 according to this corpus?

9. Source Notes

Primary narrative spine adapted from Associated Press public timeline reporting on the Iran war and related talks (including dated entries from 28 February through 8 July 2026 and follow-on AP/Al Jazeera coverage of 9-10 July exchanges).

Additional detail on opening strikes, Lebanon operations, and MoU language drawn from open encyclopedic timelines of the 2026 Iran war and contemporaneous agency summaries (e.g., Anadolu Agency 108-day overview).

Users of this RAG lab should treat answers as grounded only in this PDF unless new documents are ingested. Prefer citing dates and section headings when answering.